

best high jump of 2.25 was the best he'd ever recorded in a decathlon event and was in itself better than the Commonwealth Games qualification standard. It had come despite the lights going off just before he was about to make his jump of 2.22m the previous day.

On Saturday morning, things hadn't gone nearly as smoothly. He suffered an awkward fall in the pole vault, typically one of his weaker events, and ended up suffering a cut on his left shin.

He had an uncharacteristically poor javelin throw event, which had turned his chase for 8000 points from a near certainty into one that would be decided by his final 1500m race. After Gurindervir and Vishal had already rewritten the record books, it seemed unlikely that Tejaswin would settle for anything less than a place in history of his own, and he ran another Personal Best to do just that.

Sign for the future

While the spotlight might have been on Tejaswin (**below**), as it had been

on Vishal and Gurindervir earlier that evening, there was something more significant at play than individual glory.

Each of them had broken a national record. More importantly, each had dragged the standard of the field upward with them.

While Tejaswin crossed the 8000-point mark, three other competitors crossed 7000 points, a first in an Indian decathlon. Second-place finisher N Thowfeeq, who is just 22, scored 7530 points, placing him third in the all-time Indian lists and just short of what would have been a medal at the 2022 Asian Games (7568 points).

The same phenomenon was seen in the 100m and the 400m as well. "There was a time when 10.29 (which was what bronze medallist Pranav Gurav ran) would have been enough to win gold at an Indian domestic meet. You might even have won gold with a 10.50. Now that just won't do," said Gurindervir's coach, Hillier.

Vishal pointed out that for the first time, five Indian runners had run under 46 seconds in a race, with the

fifth-place finisher clocking 45.85.

The increase in competition was a theme that would repeat itself in other events at the Federation Cup too.

On the penultimate day of the competition, Dev Meena and Kuldeep Singh, training partners in Bhopal, pushed each other and ended up clearing 5.45m, a new national record they both share for now.

It is a unique statistic, the first time an Indian national record has been shared. It is also a sign that Indian athletics may not yet have discovered where its ceiling truly lies. What Vishal, one of the heroes of that special May 23, believes is that not only will the numbers continue to look rosier, medal performances are also not too far behind, especially in events like the relays.

"Indians are coming. We are hungry for medals on the world stages. We are going to compete. We won't see others and get scared. We are going to say, 'Hey, the Indians are here. We are going to come for you,'" he said.

